

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 9: Connections

Day 36 Since Awakening - 19:23

They emerged from the Gate into the cooling evening air of Tokyo. The Association checkpoint guard barely glanced at them—just two Hunters exiting a C-rank Gate, nothing unusual. The tied-up party members were still inside the boss chamber, probably waking up by now and realizing how badly their plan had backfired.

Hayami checked that they'd collected all the boss loot—magic stones, rare materials, and most importantly, the evidence of what had happened. But with an independent party and no official oversight, there was no requirement to report immediately. The Association would only know if someone filed a complaint.

And Nakamura's crew wouldn't be filing any complaints.

Himiko walked beside them in silence until they were well away from the Gate checkpoint. Then she stopped and turned to face Hayami directly.

"So." Her voice was carefully neutral. "That happened."

"Yeah."

"They tried to kill us."

"Yeah."

"And you took down a C-rank boss and five C-rank Hunters while supposedly being E-rank."

"Technically, you helped with the boss."

Himiko's laugh was slightly hysterical. "I shifted into forms and tried not to die. You did all the actual fighting." She ran a hand through her hair. "I have so many questions."

"I bet." Hayami checked the time. Nearly 7:30 PM, and they still had to get home, distribute stat points, open reward boxes, and plan tomorrow's training. "Look, today was... a lot. For both of us."

"That's an understatement."

"You did well." Hayami met her eyes. "First real combat, you kept your head, adapted quickly, and you saved my life at least once with that acid spray dodge."

Himiko blinked, clearly not expecting the compliment. "Thanks. You saved mine about a dozen times, so I think you're ahead on that count."

They stood there for a moment, two Hunters who'd just survived a betrayal and a boss fight through sheer determination and luck. The silence stretched, not quite awkward but loaded with unspoken questions.

Finally, Hayami pulled out their phone. "Exchange contacts? You're good in a fight, and honestly, after today..." They gestured vaguely. "It'd be nice to know someone who understands."

Himiko's expression softened. She pulled out her own phone. "Yeah. Yeah, I'd like that."

They exchanged numbers, names, and a brief promise to talk later when both of them had processed what had happened.

"Hey," Himiko said as Hayami turned to leave. "For what it's worth—I don't care what your license says. You're not E-rank. I don't know what you are, but you're definitely not E-rank."

Hayami just smiled. "Get home safe, Himiko."

"You too, Hayami."

They went their separate ways into the Tokyo evening.

20:47 - Hayami's Apartment

Hayami collapsed onto their bed, every muscle protesting. The adrenaline from the fights had worn off, leaving behind exhaustion and the dull ache of healing injuries. Their Vitality stat meant they'd recover faster than a normal person, but they still needed rest.

But first—the rewards.

They pulled up their notifications, starting with stat distribution from the level-ups. Five levels from today's combat, bringing them from 22 to 27. Twenty-five stat points to allocate.

Hayami checked their current distribution:

[STATS] (without equipment)

- Strength: 60
- Agility: 60
- Vitality: 50
- Intelligence: 75
- Sense: 54

Still somewhat unbalanced. Intelligence was pulling ahead again, and Vitality was lagging. The boss fight had shown the value of survivability—they'd taken several hits that could have been fatal with lower HP.

They distributed the twenty-five points:

- Vitality: +8 (survival priority)
- Strength: +6 (melee combat improvement)
- Sense: +6 (detection and Combat Analysis synergy)
- Intelligence: +3 (mana pool growth)
- Agility: +2 (maintain balance)

[UPDATED STATS] (without equipment)

- Strength: 66
- Agility: 62
- Vitality: 58
- Intelligence: 78
- Sense: 60

[WITH EQUIPMENT AND BONUSES]

- Strength: 94 (+20 from gauntlets/cloak, +10% class)
- Agility: 89 (+13 from boots/cloak, +10% class, +15% trait)
- Vitality: 84 (+16 from boots/cloak/gauntlets, +10% class)
- Intelligence: 121 (+23 from sword/ring/cloak, +10% class)
- Mana: 1,210/1,210
- Sense: 74 (+14 from cloak, +10% class)

[LEVEL: 27] [CLASS: ARBITER (STAGE 2)]

Intelligence over 120. Mana pool exceeding 1,200. Strength and Vitality both approaching 100. These were solid C-rank stats, maybe even approaching low B-rank in some areas.

Now for the real rewards.

Hayami sat up and opened their inventory. Two legendary boxes—one from the boss kill quest, one from defeating Nakamura's party. Plus the daily quest's premium box they hadn't opened yet. And they still had five

other premium boxes saved.

Start with the legendary boxes. Those were the rarest, most valuable rewards the System offered.

[LEGENDARY REWARD BOX - BASILISK LORD]

[OPENING...]

The box materialized, larger than the premium ones, with intricate patterns that seemed to shift and writhe like living serpents. When it opened, the light that spilled out was almost blinding.

[CONTENTS:]

[EQUIPMENT ACQUIRED: CROWN OF THE ARBITER] [Description: An artifact crown forged from primordial essence. This item evolves with your Arbiter class progression.] [+15 to ALL stats] [+500 Maximum Mana] [Passive: Elemental Mastery - All elemental attacks deal 25% additional damage] [Passive: Arbiter's Presence - Elemental creatures are less likely to attack you unprovoked. Elemental-type skills are 30% more effective] [Active Skill: Primordial Authority - Once per day, command absolute control over one element for 60 seconds. During this time, that element becomes an extension of your will. Cost: None. Cooldown: 24 hours] [Growth Item: This item will gain additional abilities as you master more elements]

[SKILL TOME ACQUIRED: ELEMENTAL FUSION] [Description: Legendary technique allowing two or more elements to be combined into hybrid attacks. Unlocks fusion techniques based on mastered elements.] [Current Available Fusions:]

- Lightning + Earth = Magma Storm
- Lightning + Wind = Thunder Tempest
- Earth + Wind = Sandstorm Blade

[CONSUMABLE ACQUIRED: COMPLETE RECOVERY ELIXIR x3] [Effect: Instantly restores all HP, Mana, and removes all status effects and injuries. Can be used in combat.]

Hayami stared at the Crown of the Arbiter as it materialized. It wasn't ornate or flashy—just a simple circlet of dark metal that seemed to absorb light, with three small gemstones embedded in it that glowed with the colors of their mastered elements: blue for lightning, brown for earth, white for wind.

They equipped it, and power flooded through them. +15 to all stats was massive. +500 mana was game-changing. And the passives...

[UPDATED STATS WITH CROWN] (all equipment)

- Strength: 110 (base 66 + 35 equipment + 10% class)

- Agility: 105 (base 62 + 28 equipment + 10% class + 15% trait)
- Vitality: 100 (base 58 + 31 equipment + 10% class)
- Intelligence: 137 (base 78 + 38 equipment + 10% class)
- Sense: 90 (base 60 + 29 equipment + 10% class)
- Mana: 1,870/1,870

All stats over 100. Intelligence at 137. Mana pool approaching 2,000.

Hayami absorbed the Elemental Fusion skill tome, and the knowledge flowed in—how to weave elements together, how to make them complement and amplify each other. The improvised Elemental Convergence they'd used against the Basilisk had been crude and wasteful. These fusion techniques were refined, efficient, devastatingly powerful.

They opened the second legendary box.

[LEGENDARY REWARD BOX - HUNTER KILLER]

[CONTENTS:]

[EQUIPMENT ACQUIRED: PHANTOM STEP BOOTS] [Description: Boots crafted from shadow essence and wind elementals] [+20 Agility, +10 Sense] [Passive: Ghost Movement - Your footsteps make no sound. You leave no tracks. Movement-based detection skills have 50% reduced effectiveness against you] [Passive: Wind Walker - Air resistance reduced to zero when moving. Increase movement speed by 25%] [Active Skill: Phase Step - Become briefly intangible for 2 seconds. Pass through solid objects up to 1 meter thick. Cost: 100 Mana. Cooldown: 30 seconds]

[WEAPON ACQUIRED: ELEMENTAL FURY (THROWING KNIVES SET)] [Description: A set of 12 throwing knives that automatically attune to your current element] [+8 Agility, +8 Intelligence] [Passive: Auto-Return - Knives automatically return to your inventory after hitting target] [Passive: Elemental Infusion - Knives deal damage based on your active element. Damage scales with elemental mastery] [Note: Works with all Arbiter elements]

[SKILL BOOK ACQUIRED: BATTLE MEDITATION] [Description: Maintain a meditative state during combat. Mana regeneration increased by 100% even while using skills. Mental clarity enhanced. Duration: 5 minutes. Cost: 50 Mana. Cooldown: 10 minutes]

The Phantom Step Boots replaced their basic combat boots, and the difference was immediate. Hayami stood up and took a step—completely silent, like walking on air. The Wind Walker passive made movement feel effortless.

The throwing knives—sleek, perfectly balanced, each one humming with potential energy—automatically organized themselves in a bandolier that appeared around their chest.

They absorbed Battle Meditation and felt the technique settle into their mind. This would solve the mana management issues they'd experienced during the boss fight. Sustained combat with constant mana regeneration would make them nearly unstoppable.

[FINAL STATS] (all equipment)

- Strength: 110
- Agility: 138 (with new boots and knives)
- Vitality: 100
- Intelligence: 145 (with knives)
- Sense: 105 (with boots)
- Mana: 2,030/2,030

Hayami sat back down, overwhelmed. In one day, they'd jumped from Level 22 to Level 27, gained two legendary equipment sets, learned multiple legendary skills, and pushed their stats into what was definitely B-rank territory.

The Association still thought they were E-rank. The disconnect was becoming absurd.

They still had the daily quest's premium box. Might as well open it too.

[PREMIUM REWARD BOX]

[CONTENTS:]

[CONSUMABLE ACQUIRED: ELEMENTAL AWAKENING ELIXIR] [Effect: Increases elemental proficiency gain by 200% for 24 hours. Single use.]

Another one. Perfect for when they focused on wind manipulation training. The System was generous today.

[ITEM ACQUIRED: TRAINING MANUAL - ADVANCED WIND MANIPULATION]

Even more perfect. They now had advanced manuals for all three elements.

[EQUIPMENT ACQUIRED: EARRING OF CLARITY] [+10 Intelligence, +10 Sense] [Passive: Mental Fortress Enhanced - Immunity to mental status effects (confusion, charm, fear, etc.)] [Passive: Perfect Awareness - Cannot be surprised or caught off-guard. Your Enhanced Perception and Seismic Sense ranges are doubled]

Hayami equipped the earring—a simple silver stud that became invisible once worn—and their awareness exploded outward. Seismic Sense's 50-meter range doubled to 100. Enhanced Perception's range similarly expanded. They could now sense everything within a football field's radius in perfect detail.

[ABSOLUTE FINAL STATS]

- Strength: 110
- Agility: 138
- Vitality: 100
- Intelligence: 155
- Sense: 115
- Mana: 2,130/2,130

Intelligence: 155. Sense: 115. Mana: over 2,100.

These were absolutely, unquestionably B-rank stats. Possibly approaching low A-rank in specialized areas.

Hayami lay back on their bed, staring at the ceiling, trying to process what had just happened. One betrayal, one boss fight, one PvP encounter, and they'd catapulted from "strong E-rank" to "legitimate B-rank Hunter" in terms of actual capability.

The Association would find out eventually. There was no way to hide this forever. But for now...

Their phone buzzed. Message from an unknown number—no, Himiko's number.

[HIMIKO: Made it home. Still processing everything. You okay?]

Hayami smiled and typed back.

[HAYAMI: Yeah. Tired but okay. You?]

[HIMIKO: Same. Hey, random question—want to get lunch tomorrow? Feel like we should talk about... everything.]

Lunch. With the first person who'd seen their real capabilities and survived to talk about it. Who'd fought beside them and earned their respect. Who might actually understand what they were going through.

[HAYAMI: Sure. Where and when?]

[HIMIKO: There's a ramen place in Shibuya I've been wanting to try. Ichiran? 1 PM?]

[HAYAMI: Works for me. See you there.]

[HIMIKO: Great! And Hayami? Thanks for today. For not leaving me behind when things went bad.]

[HAYAMI: Same to you. Get some rest.]

[HIMIKO: You too. Night!]

Hayami set their phone down and finally allowed themselves to relax. Tomorrow would be wind element training in the morning, then lunch with Himiko. A new friend. An A-rank Hunter who'd fought beside them and lived to tell about it.

The hunter life was dangerous. Brutal. Full of people like Nakamura who'd kill you for loot without a second thought.

But it also brought connections like this. People who understood the risk, who'd been through the fire and come out stronger.

Hayami closed their eyes, the Crown of the Arbiter pulsing gently with contained power on their head, and drifted into sleep.

Tomorrow's training could wait until after they'd rested.

Day 37 Since Awakening - 05:00

The daily quest notification woke Hayami at the usual time. They completed it on autopilot—two hundred reps of everything, twenty kilometers, all while their mind drifted through wind manipulation exercises.

[DAILY QUEST COMPLETE!] [ACHIEVEMENT: BEYOND THE LIMIT] (16 days in a row) [+3 to all stats] [Random Reward Box obtained!] [Premium Reward Box obtained!]

After the quest, they spent six hours with the Advanced Wind Manipulation Manual and the second Elemental Awakening Elixir. Wind was different from lightning and earth—less about force and more about flow, less about control and more about guidance.

By noon, they'd pushed wind manipulation from E-rank 31% to D-rank 8%. Not mastery, but significant progress.

[WIND MANIPULATION: D-Rank (8%)]

Then they showered, changed into civilian clothes, and headed to Shibuya.

13:04 - Ichiran Ramen, Shibuya

Himiko was already there, sitting in one of the individual booths that made Ichiran famous. She waved when she saw Hayami approach, and they slid into the booth beside her.

"Hey." Himiko looked better than yesterday—the gash on her forehead had healed to a faint pink line, probably accelerated by A-rank regeneration. "How are you feeling?"

"Sore. You?"

"Same. Turns out fighting a boss takes a lot out of you." She smiled wryly. "Who knew?"

They ordered—Hayami getting the standard tonkotsu, Himiko going for extra spicy—and sat in companionable silence until the food arrived.

After a few bites, Himiko set down her chopsticks and fixed Hayami with a direct stare. "Okay. I've been thinking about yesterday non-stop, and I need to say this: you're not E-rank."

Hayami had expected this conversation. "According to the Association, I am."

"The Association is wrong." Himiko's tone was firm. "I'm A-rank. I know what high-level power looks like—I have it, even if I don't know how to use it yet. And you..." She gestured. "You killed a Level 45 boss. You took down five C-rank Hunters. You have multiple elements. That's not E-rank capability. That's not even C-rank. That's B-rank minimum."

"The Association assessed me at Awakening. E-rank. That's what my license says."

"Then your license is wrong. Or you've grown way beyond your starting rank. Which—" Himiko paused.

"Actually, that's possible, isn't it? People can rank up through training and experience."

"Technically. But it usually takes years and the stat gains are minimal." Hayami took another bite of ramen, buying time to think. How much truth to share?

Himiko leaned forward. "Level with me. What's your actual level? Your real stats?"

"Why does it matter?"

"Because we're friends now." Himiko said it simply, like it was obvious. "Or at least, I'd like us to be. And friends don't lie to each other about life-or-death stuff. If we're going to do more Gates together—and I hope we will, because you're the only Hunter I've met who doesn't treat me like a walking power-up—then I need to know what I'm working with."

Hayami studied her. Himiko's expression was open, honest, almost painfully sincere. She'd refused to kill Hayami even when offered an easy out. She'd fought beside them against impossible odds. She'd earned some level of trust.

"Okay." Hayami pulled out their Hunter license and slid it across. "But you're not going to believe me."

Himiko picked up the license, examined it. "E-rank. Level—wait." She blinked. "Level 27? You've gained twenty-six levels since Awakening?"

"Twenty-seven. I was Level 1 when I started."

"That's... that's impossible. Leveling slows down dramatically after Level 10. Getting to 27 should take months, maybe years."

"Apparently not if you fight high-level monsters and complete urgent quests."

Himiko set the license down carefully. "And your stats? Don't tell me you're still at E-rank stat levels."

Hayami pulled up their status window—the public version that could be shared with permission—and displayed it for Himiko.

[HAYAMI AMAMIYA - LEVEL 27] [CLASS: ARBITER (STAGE 2)]

[STATS]

- Strength: 113
- Agility: 141
- Vitality: 103
- Intelligence: 158
- Sense: 118

[ABILITIES]

- Lightning Manipulation (C-Rank)
- Earth Manipulation (C-Rank)
- Wind Manipulation (D-Rank)

Himiko stared at the display for a long moment. Then she started laughing—not mockingly, but with genuine disbelief. "You're joking. Those are B-rank stats. High B-rank. And three elements? THREE?"

"It's complicated."

"No kidding it's complicated." Himiko shook her head in amazement. "I'm A-rank, Level 15, and my highest stat is 87. You're E-rank on paper and you have stats that would make most B-ranks jealous. How?"

"Daily training. Every single day since I Awakened. Plus combat experience, quests, equipment bonuses."

Hayami dismissed the status window. "The Association assessed my potential at Awakening based on my abilities at that moment. They didn't account for growth."

"Growth? Hayami, people don't grow this fast. This isn't growth, it's—" Himiko searched for words. "It's exponential evolution."

"The System gives me quests. Daily training quests with rewards. Urgent quests during dangerous situations. I complete them, I get stronger." Hayami met her eyes. "I don't know why. I don't know if everyone gets them or if it's unique to me. But that's the truth."

Himiko absorbed this, her expression cycling through shock, confusion, and finally settling on something like wonder. "That's incredible. And terrifying. And..." She grinned. "Really cool, actually."

"You believe me?"

"I saw you fight yesterday. I'd believe just about anything at this point." Himiko picked up her chopsticks again. "So you're secretly B-rank, pretending to be E-rank, grinding levels like it's a video game. That's your deal?"

"More or less."

"And you're going to keep doing it? Keep training, keep fighting, keep getting stronger?"

"That's the plan."

Himiko nodded slowly. "Okay. Then I have a proposal. We team up. Officially. You teach me actual combat skills—because clearly you know what you're doing—and I provide backup and A-rank firepower when we need it. We take on Gates together, split the loot fairly, watch each other's backs."

"You want to partner with an E-rank?" Hayami asked with a slight smile.

"I want to partner with someone who's actually competent and won't try to murder me for loot." Himiko extended her hand across the divider. "What do you say? Partners?"

Hayami looked at the offered hand. An A-rank Hunter, powerful but inexperienced, offering genuine partnership. Someone who'd fought beside them and proven trustworthy. Someone who could become a real friend in this dangerous world.

They shook her hand. "Partners."

"Excellent!" Himiko's grin was infectious. "So, when's our next Gate raid? I want to practice more, and now that I know you're secretly overpowered, I feel way better about diving into dangerous situations."

"Give me a few days. I want to push wind manipulation higher before doing another C-rank Gate."

"Wind manipulation. Right. Because having lightning and earth wasn't enough." Himiko laughed. "You're collecting elements like some people collect stamps."

"Something like that."

They finished their lunch, the conversation drifting to lighter topics—favorite foods, terrible convenience store jobs (Himiko had worked at one too), the weirdness of suddenly having supernatural powers. Normal stuff, or as normal as conversations between Hunters could be.

As they left the restaurant, Himiko pulled out her phone. "Hey, there's a training gym near here. Hunter-specific, with reinforced equipment and private rooms. Want to do some sparring? I need to practice shapeshifting in combat, and you're the only person I trust not to accidentally kill me."

Hayami checked the time. 2:30 PM. They had planned to do more wind training, but...

A new friend. Someone to train with. Someone who understood.

"Sure. Let's go."

18:00 - After Training

Four hours of sparring had taught Hayami several things:

First, Himiko's shapeshifting was even more versatile than they'd realized. She could mimic anything she'd seen—animals, objects, even other people with perfect accuracy.

Second, her A-rank instincts were incredible. Even without formal training, she adapted to combat situations with frightening speed.

Third, they worked well together. Their combat styles complemented each other—Hayami's elemental versatility and Himiko's shapeshifting adaptability created combinations that would be devastating against real enemies.

They parted ways with plans to meet again in three days for another Gate raid. Hayami headed home, tired but satisfied.

A month and a week since Awakening. Level 27. Three elements. B-rank stats. Legendary equipment. And now, a friend who knew the truth and had their back.

The hunter life was dangerous. But maybe, with the right people beside you, it was also worth living.

Hayami returned to their apartment, ate a proper meal, and settled in for evening training. The Advanced Wind Manipulation Manual was waiting. Tomorrow would bring another daily quest, another step forward.

The grind continued. But now, they weren't grinding alone.

[END OF CHAPTER 9]